Dear Professor McLarney,

At the start of the semester, I came into this course both curious and intimidated by poetry. I'd written countless poems with the same rhyming structure for years, thinking that rhyme was what made a poem "work". I love rhythms and neatness, but I often used rhyme to control meaning instead of explore it. When I came to this class, I realized how much more poetry could hold, how sound, syntax, and line breaks could create emotional depth that rhyme alone couldn't.

Early on, I saw poetry as something fixed, almost like a puzzle to solve. Through this course and our readings, I learned that poetry can breathe; it can be messy, raw, and alive. The workshop process helped me loosen my grip or form and focus more on voice, music, and vulnerability. Poets like Keats, Trimble, and Baker showed me that beauty and imperfection can coexist, and that emotion doesn't have to rhyme to resonate.

Across my portfolio, I see a thread of learning to reach, toward others, toward self-acceptance, toward clarity. Each poem began as something small and formal, but through revision, I leaned into texture, openness, and honesty. The four poems, "In the Reaching", "I Write Myself More", "Call Me a Dummy, Hold Me Close", and "What Happens Next", track that development from an external sense of beauty and worth to an internal one. They're linked by vulnerability, reflection, and a willingness to let imperfection become a form of music.

"In the Reaching" began as "To Live Is To Sing", a traditional, rhymed reflection on beauty and pain modeled after Romantic lyricism, particularly Keat's "Ode to a Nightingale." Like Keats, I wanted to explore how beauty and sorrow coexist, but in my early draft, I was more focused on rhyme and neatness than depth, I was writing about emotion rather than through it. After workshop feedback, I realized the strict rhyme limited my emotional range, and my peers reminded me I didn't have to rely on it. In the second version, "In the Reaching", I shifted to free verse and added a personal element, connecting Keat's idea of beauty born from transience to my own experience with physical disability and love. I used enjambment and repetition ("the way you show up, flow up") to create a rhythm that feels spoken, almost like breath. In the last version, and after getting feedback from Ms. McLarney, she didn't like the phrase "the way you show up, flow up" and didn't think it flowed nicely, and she also didn't clearly understand what "flow up" meant, and I understood where she was coming from, so I changed it to "the way you showed up, steady" for it to make more sense. For the overall poem, the focus moved from general observation to embodied experience: beauty as effort, love as translation. I'm proud of how the final version balances lyric and confessional tones without sentimentality.

The original, "Headlines and Margins", explored resilience and self-definition but felt like a declaration rather than a lived moment. After workshop, I deepened the second version by layering imagery and cadence, focusing less on asserting strength and more on showing how it's earned. In revision, I changed the title to "I Write Myself More" and expanded the metaphors of wildflowers, writing, and soil, allowing them to grow into a clearer theme of survival and growth. I expanded the writing metaphor because, in his notes, Davis said it would be cool to go

further down the writing route, perhaps because of my original title. Even though it was just a one-time suggestion, it opened a direction I wouldn't have explored otherwise. I wanted the rhythm to feel deliberate but open, with short, weighted phrases. I also incorporated accessibility and disability more directly, transforming the poem from empowerment rhetoric into an act of reclamation. "When the world says / I am less, / I write myself more" became its emotional hinge, simple, rhythmic, but defiant. In the final version, it feels both intimate and universal, something I'd like to keep refining through compression and sound.

"Call Me a Dummy, Hold Me Close" grew from a personal, romantic space and became a structural experiment in the obverse form, where the second half mirrors the first in reverse. The early version was heartfelt but conventional, focusing on self-doubt and reassurance. After revising, and after hearing in workshop that I should turn this poem into an obverse and include more of my partner's voice, I introduced dialogue, realism, and a sense of mutuality, shaping love as an act of emotional care between two people who each grapple with their own perceived brokenness. I included more of my partner's language and responses, turning the poem into a shared voice rather than a single confession. The mirrored structure reinforced that idea, two halves seeing and saving each other in reflection. The reversal was technically difficult, but it gave the poem symmetry and closure while maintaining tenderness.

"What Happens Next" began as "Everything, All at Once, All the Time", a stream of consciousness born from anxiety about post-graduation life. I originally wrote it as a literal outpouring of panic, raw, unfiltered, but realized during revision that it could gain power through organized chaos. The second version of the poem I added section titles to shape the spiral: *The Question, The Barrier, The Uncertainty, The Spiral,* etc. Each heading presents a mental phase in overthinking over a heavy situation, breaking the poem into fragments that mimic thought patterns but remain readable. This structure captures the way fear loops on itself while offering the reader breath between waves. My meeting with Ms. McLarney helped clarify what the poem needed for the final version: tightening the language and digging deeper into the two relationships at its center. Those are the parts that feel the most honest, and I think they're the parts readers will see themselves in, whether it's navigating a parent who's overly protective or wondering what will happen to a relationship after graduation. I also revised with the intention of making the poem resonate beyond Auburn, so it speaks to a wider audience.

Looking back, I'm proud of how much more comfortable I've become with vulnerability and imperfection. A reason I got so much courage to dive into that vulnerability is partly because of Amelia and each of her raw, vulnerable poems that she shared about heavy topics she or someone she knows has experienced. All in all, I learned to see form as something that can serve emotion rather than restrain it. Workshop feedback taught me to listen, to my own language, to silence, to rhythm. I've discovered that my strongest poems balance clarity and confession: poems that reach rather than declare. If I had more time, I'd like to tighten the longer pieces, deepen sensory imagery, and continue experimenting with sound as emotional structure. Going forward, I plan to keep revising and writing more poems. My hope is that my poetry continues to

hold space for softness, struggle, and resilience, especially the intersections of disability, identity, and love.

Thank you for guiding me toward finding my truest poetic voice.

Sincerely,

Lizzie McGlynn

To Live Is to Sing – First Version (Poem 1)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

Your song reminds me beauty is not plain,
It grows through the trials, the sorrow, the pain.
The sweetest of moments press close to the ache,
Rough roads behind every joy we take.

The nightingale sings, and the song is sweet,
Sweet because we know it will not repeat.
Its notes rise high, yet they soon must fall,
Teaching us fleeting can still mean all.

You cannot have joy without sorrow near,
Happiness fades if no loss is clear.
Sorrow instructs us to love what we hold,
It makes each heartbeat more bright, more bold.

Joy shines brighter like sunlight through rain,
Like spring returning when winter is slain.
The bird's clear song is a gift, not a chain,
A moment of beauty that eases our pain.

To live is to carry both shadow and flame,
To treasure the fragile and love all the same.
Keats was right, your song does not deceive:
Beauty is bittersweet, for it longs to leave.

In the Reaching – Second Version (Poem 1)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

Your song belongs, prolongs, reminds me that beauty is layered.
It does not arrive clean or plain, or simple, or spared.
It grows in the middle of trials and miles,
in the weight of sorrow, the borrowed tomorrows,
in the pain that refuses to fade quietly.

There is a song in the air, rare, light yet restless, unsteady.
It lingers long enough to be felt,
never long enough to be held.
I know myself in that music, intrinsic,
a presence both fragile and strong,
a beauty that matters because it will not stay.

My body does not move the way I wish it could.
Some tasks demand a plan, a span,
between what I imagine and what I can carry out.
Sometimes I resent it, lament it,
other times I wonder if the struggle
makes my joy sharper, brighter, awake.

Your language, ours between us, built from action, reaction,
the way you show up, flow up,
the way you fix, protect, provide.
Mine lives in whispered confessions at night,
in holding your hand through crowded streets,
in tracing your face when words fall short.
We stumble, fumble,
not knowing how to translate.
Yet, the reaching matters,
the effort holds us together.

Beauty, then, is not soft,
It is brief, piercing, unsteady.
It grows beside sorrow,
it does not erase it.
To live is to carry both shadow and flame,
to learn again and again,
that even in the reaching,
we are whole, enfolded, and brave.

In the Reaching – Final Version (Poem 1)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

Your song belongs, prolongs, reminds me that beauty is layered.
It does not arrive clean or plain, or simple, or spared.
It grows in the middle of trials and miles,
in the weight of sorrow, the borrowed tomorrows,
in the pain that refuses to fade quietly.

There is a song in the air, rare, light yet restless, unsteady.
It lingers long enough to be felt,
never long enough to be held.
I know myself in that music, intrinsic,
a presence both fragile and strong,
a beauty that matters because it will not stay.

My body does not move the way I wish it could.
Some tasks demand a plan, a span,
between what I imagine and what I can carry out.
Sometimes I resent it, lament it,
other times I wonder if the struggle
makes my joy sharper, brighter, awake.

Your language, ours between us, built from action, reaction,
the way you show up, steady,
the way you fix, protect, provide.
Mine lives in whispered confessions at night,
in holding your hand through crowded streets,
in tracing your face when words fall short.
We stumble, fumble,
not knowing how to translate.
Yet, the reaching matters,
the effort holds us together.

Beauty, then, is not soft,
It is brief, piercing, unsteady.
It grows beside sorrow,
it does not erase it.
To live is to carry both shadow and flame,
to learn again and again,
that even in the reaching,
we are whole, enfolded, and brave.

Headlines and Margins – First Version (Poem 2)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

I have been read like a headline,
but I promise myself this:
I am not a story of lack.
I am a story of becoming.
For every eye that skimmed past me,
I offer my own gaze, steady, soft, the kind that lingers without judgment.
I see myself whole.
I carry scars, yes,
but I press them like wildflowers
between the pages of my life,
reminders that I survived
and kept blooming.
When the world says I am less, I write myself more.
I fill my margins with laughter, with tenderness, with the stubborn beauty of my own making.

I am not their misprint. I am my own love letter, sealed with defiance, delivered with care,
signed in my truest name.

I Write Myself More – Second Version (Poem 2)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

I have been read like a headline,
summarized, simplified,
but I promise myself this:
I am not a story of lack.
I am a story of becoming.

For every eye
that skimmed past me,
I offer my own gaze,
steady, soft,
the kind that lingers
without judgment.
I see myself whole.

I carry scars, yes,
from learning to move
through a world
that often measured me
by assuming immediately
I'm less than,
not giving me a chance
to prove myself,
from hands that trembled
but never stopped reaching,
from voices that confused
my softness
for something fragile.

But I press those scars
like wildflowers
between the pages
of my life,
petal-thin reminders
that beauty can outlast
the season that hurt it.

Proof that I survived
being placed into boxes
I never belonged in,
the quiet sting

of being stereotyped
for what I look like
on the outside,
the exhaustion
of constantly having to show
I am more than assumptions.

Still,
I kept blooming,
in soil that wasn't soft,
in weather that wasn't kind,
rooted by will alone.
I learned
that even wildflowers
can write their own survival
into the dirt,
can turn sunlight
into sentences.

When the world says
I am less,
I write myself more.

Because writing
is where I breathe freely,
where I press ink to page
and feel my heart unfold.
Writing is my garden,
where I plant what I've lost,
where I tend to what still hurts
until it grows
into something gentle.

It lets me gather
the broken pieces
and arrange them like petals,
like constellations,
each word a seed
that remembers how to live.

It's how I remember
who I am
when the world
tries to tell me otherwise.

I write of laughter
that fills small rooms,
of the fierce grace
in my steady hands,
of the way I hold people
gently,
because I know
what it's like
to need gentleness
and not find it.

I tell myself,
You are enough.
You are radiant
in your becoming.

You've built a life
from persistence and prayer,
from coffee cups
and poetry,
from the stubborn beauty
of staying.

I am not their misprint.
I am my own love letter,
sealed with defiance,
delivered with care,
signed
in my truest name:

Lizzie.

I Write Myself More – Final Version (Poem 2)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

I have been read like a headline,
summarized, simplified,
but I promise myself this:
I am not a story of lack.
I am a story of becoming.

For every eye
that skimmed past me,
I offer my own gaze,
steady, soft,
the kind that lingers
without judgment.
I see myself whole.

I carry scars, yes,
from learning to move
through a world
that often measured me
by assuming immediately
I'm less than,
not giving me a chance
to prove myself,
from hands that trembled
but never stopped reaching,
from voices that confused
my softness
for something fragile.

But I press those scars
like wildflowers
between the pages
of my life,
petal-thin reminders
that beauty can outlast
the season that hurt it.

Still,
I kept blooming,
in soil that wasn't soft,
in weather that wasn't kind,

rooted by will alone.
I learned
that even wildflowers
can write their own survival
into the dirt,
can turn sunlight
into sentences.

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I am less,
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It lets me gather
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I am not their misprint.
I am my own love letter,
sealed with defiance,
delivered with care,
signed
in my truest name:

Lizzie.

Call Me a Dummy, Hold Me Close – First Version (Poem 3)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

Even when I look in the mirror and doubt,
My Love,
you catch my gaze and remind me through
your eyes:
"I see you," you say, "all of you, my heart."
Your words wrap around me, filled with love,
and suddenly I feel a little perfect,
even when I call myself a dummy.

I laugh at myself, admit it, "I'm a dummy,"
and shake your head, smiling at me,
My Love.
But in that moment, I also feel perfect,
because you see past the worry in my eyes.
You pour your gentle, endless love
into the corners of my fragile heart.

Sometimes my heart aches at its own dummy
thoughts, the ones that whisper I'm not
perfect.
But then you reach for me, soft with love,
and I feel it again, you, My Love.
Your gaze steadies the storm in my eyes,

and I remember: I am perfect to you.

Even when we do something silly,
call each other dummy,
laughing so loud our hearts shake, My Love,
I see how deep your love is in your eyes,
and I realize: these moments make me
perfect.
The world may whisper otherwise, but my
heart
knows that with you, all of me is love.

You remind me constantly with your eyes,
that I'm not broken, not less – not a dummy.
You reach into my heart and pull out love,
holding me steady, calm, My Love.
Every flaw I carry feels strangely perfect,
because your hands tell me it's perfect to you.

So I'll call myself a dummy more often,
My Love,
and still feel perfect through your eyes,
because this love fills my heart, makes
everything perfect.

Call Me a Dummy, Hold Me Close – Second Version (Poem 3)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

Even when I look in the mirror and doubt,
my love,
you catch my gaze and remind me through your eyes:
"I see you," you whisper, "all of you, my heart."
Your words wrap around me, filled with love,
and suddenly I feel a little perfect,
even when I call myself a dummy.

We call each other dummy when our minds turn cruel,
when you think you're not enough,
and I start to see my disability as something wrong.
You laugh softly and say,
"Hey, quit that. You're not broken, just different, just real."
Then you shake your head, smiling at me,
and in that moment, I feel perfect;
you see past the worry in my eyes.

Sometimes my heart aches at its own dummy
thoughts, the ones that whisper I'm not perfect.
You reach for me, soft with love,
and I feel it again, you, my love.
You say, "You don't have to earn being enough.
You already are."
Your gaze steadies the storm in my eyes,
and I remember: I am perfect to you.

And when you go quiet, shut out the noise,
feeling like a bad person for needing to vanish,
I reach for you the same way you do for me.
"I see you," I tell you, "even in silence.
You're not bad, my love. You're human.
You're allowed to rest, to disappear for a while."
And you look at me, tired,
but lighter somehow.

When you look in the mirror and doubt,
I catch your gaze and tell you the same:
"I see you, all of you, my heart."
I mean it with everything in me,

the way you mean it with me.
Because my love, you are perfect to me too.

Because my love, you are perfect to me too.
I mean it with everything in me,
the way you mean it with me.
“I see you, all of you, my heart.”
I catch your gaze and tell you the same
when you look in the mirror and doubt.

You look at me, tired,
but lighter somehow.
“You’re allowed to rest, to disappear for a while,”
I tell you. “You’re not bad, my love. You’re human.”
“I see you,” I say, “even in silence.”
I reach for you the same way you do for me,
when you go quiet, shut out the noise,
feeling like a bad person for needing to vanish.

I remember: I am perfect to you.
Your gaze steadies the storm in my eyes.
“You already are,” you say,
“You don’t have to earn being enough.”
I feel it again, you, my love,
soft with love,
when those dummy thoughts whisper I’m not perfect.

You see past the worry in my eyes,
and in that moment, I feel perfect.
You shake your head, smiling at me,
“Different. Real. Never broken,” you laugh softly.
When I start to see my disability as something wrong,
and you think you’re not enough,
we call each other dummy,
our kindness chasing off the cruel.

Even when I call myself a dummy,
you make me feel a little perfect.
Your words wrap around me, filled with love:
“I see you,” you whisper, “all of you, my heart.”
my love,
I catch my gaze in the mirror and no longer doubt,
I see me through your eyes.

Everything, All at Once, All the Time – First Version (Poem 4)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

I'm scared.

What is going to happen
after I graduate with my master's?
I have no idea.
I have no idea where I'm going to live,
if I'm going back to Birmingham,
if I have to leave my boyfriend,
what is going to happen there
with my boyfriend.

Are we going to break up?
Are we going to do long distance?
Can we do long distance?
Are we strong enough
to be able to do that?
I know we kind of did
at the start of our relationship
but we would see each other on weekends.
What happens when I get a full-time job?

If the job is in Birmingham, then what?
He has a demanding full-time job,
so exhausting.
He won't want to drive all the way
to Birmingham on weekends.
Weekends are his time
to fully relax and recharge.

I can't drive.
That is a huge problem,
the biggest barrier.
So I have this to worry about,
but more so I should worry
about finding a job.

Yes, I haven't graduated yet,
but I have to start looking,
even with everything
that I have on my plate.
I even have a portfolio to work on,
a requirement to graduate,

that I haven’t touched
since last semester
in my Web Development class.

What job would I be good at?
What job would I be good at
that AI hasn’t, or won’t, take?
Technical communication,
maybe writing,
content design, copywriting,
editing, something in UX.
Maybe a social media role,
though I’m not sure
I want to live my life online.
Maybe I could write for the university,
or work in accessibility,
or stay in research,
or something I haven’t yet imagined.
But how do you know
what’s right
when every path feels both open
and closing.

And then there’s my body,
the quiet thing I carry
into every room.
The way I move slower,
the way people watch too long or not at all.
Will they see my work before they see that?
Will they think I can’t do the job,
can’t keep up,
can’t manage what they never had to learn to manage?
My disability is a barrier I didn’t build,
but one I keep climbing.
Still, I worry,
what if they don’t let me through the door.

And then my mom’s voice,
steady and sure,
telling me I’m not fully ready
to live independently yet,
that I’ll be a burden to my boyfriend,
that his parents will see me
as someone he has to take care of.
The words sit in my chest
like small stones.

I tell myself they're meant to protect me,
but they grow heavier
each time I try to imagine
standing on my own.
It's hard to build confidence
when someone you love
keeps handing you reasons not to.

Is it possible that I can stay in Auburn?
I know my mom would help me
figure out a living situation
if I got a job in Auburn,
but what would be
my new method of getting around?

I already use Uber,
but Uber is expensive.
I know I'm fortunate enough
to afford Uber
since I don't drive,
but still.

Is there a job for me
at the University?

I am fully panicking.

Having to juggle my relationship
with my boyfriend,
where I'm basically fourteen
emotionally,
and this is my first true go
at a relationship,
and a job
where I have to log
fifteen hours a week,
and three classes
that somehow I'm still doing great in,

the pressure
is on my shoulders.

Is this what it looks like
to be a true adult,
barely keeping your head
above water,

juggling so much
your two hands
can’t carry everything.

And still,
I sit here thinking about it again,
and again,
until the thought folds back
into itself,
a circle that never stops,
just spins,
softly humming the same question:
what happens next,
what happens next.

What Happens Next – Second Version (Poem 4)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

<u>The Question</u>
What's going to happen
after I graduate with my master's?
I have no idea.

<u>The Where</u>
No idea where I'll live,
am I going back to Birmingham?
Am I leaving my boyfriend?
What happens there,
with him, with us?

<u>The What-Ifs</u>
Do we break up?
Do we try long distance?
Can we even do that?
Are we strong enough for it?
We kind of did it before,
at the start,
but at least we had weekends then.

<u>The Reality Check</u>
What happens when I get a full-time job?
If it's in Birmingham, then what?
He's already so tired,
his job drains him.
He won't want to drive hours
just for a weekend.
Weekends are when he finally breathes.

<u>The Barrier</u>
And me? I can't drive.
That's the wall I always hit,
the biggest barrier.

<u>The Shift</u>
So I worry about that,
and then I worry about finding a job,
because maybe that's what I *should*
be worrying about more.

The Search
Yes, I haven't graduated yet,
but I must start looking,
even with everything
that I have on my plate.
I even have a portfolio to work on,
a requirement to graduate,
that I haven't touched
since last semester
in my Web Development class.

The Uncertainty
What job would I be good at?
What job would I be good at
that AI hasn't, or won't, take?
Technical communication,
maybe writing,
content design, copywriting,
editing, something in UX.
Maybe a social media role,
though I'm not sure
I want to live my life online.
Maybe I could write for the university,
or work in accessibility,
or stay in research,
or something I haven't yet imagined.
But how do you know
what's right
when every path feels both open
and closing.

The Body
And then there's my body,
the quiet thing I carry
into every room.
The way I move slower,
the way people watch too long or not at all.
Will they see my work before they see that?
Will they think I can't do the job,
can't keep up,
can't manage what they never had to learn to manage?
My disability is a barrier I didn't build,
but one I keep climbing.
Still, I worry,
what if they don't let me through the door.

The Voice
And then my mom's voice,
steady and sure,
telling me I'm not fully ready
to live independently yet,
that I'll be a burden to my boyfriend,
that his parents will see me
as someone he has to take care of.
The words sit in my chest
like small stones.
I tell myself they're meant to protect me,
but they grow heavier
each time I try to imagine
standing on my own.
It's hard to build confidence
when someone you love
keeps handing you reasons not to.

The What-If
Is it possible that I can stay in Auburn?
I know my mom would help me
figure out a living situation
if I got a job in Auburn,
but what would be
my new method of getting around?
I already use Uber,
but Uber is expensive.
I know I'm fortunate enough
to afford Uber
since I don't drive,
but still.
Is there a job for me
at the University?

The Spiral
I am fully panicking.
Having to juggle my relationship
with my boyfriend,
where I'm basically fourteen
emotionally,
and this is my first true go
at a relationship,
and a job
where I have to log
fifteen hours a week,
and three classes

that somehow I'm still doing great in,
the pressure
is on my shoulders.
Is this what it looks like
to be a true adult,
barely keeping your head
above water,
juggling so much
your two hands
can't carry everything.

<u>The Loop</u>
And still,
I sit here thinking about it again,
and again,
until the thought folds back
into itself,
a circle that never stops,
just spins,
softly humming the same question:
what happens next,
what happens next.

What Happens Next – Final Version (Poem 4)

By: Lizzie McGlynn

The Question
What happens after I graduate with my master's?
I don't know.
My mom asks if I'm prepared,
if I can really handle what comes next.
But part of me is already scared
of losing the one thing that feels steady,
him.

The Where
Where will I live?
Back home?
My mom thinks moving back is a good idea,
that I could live with my parents for a while,
that it would be safer, easier,
more controlled.
But that would mean leaving my boyfriend.
And I don't want to leave him.
He's my safety net,
the person who softens the world
just by being in it.
My mom says home makes the most sense,
closer to her,
closer to someone who can "keep an eye on me."
But my heart keeps pointing back to him.

The What-Ifs
Do we break up?
Try long distance again?
We did it at the start,
but back then we had weekends.
Now the thought of us being hours apart
makes my stomach drop.
I don't want to lose him
to miles or timing.
My mom thinks distance will make him stop
and reconsider whether he's really up for
dealing with everything that comes with me.
But she doesn't see the way he holds me
like I matter.

The Reality Check
If moving back becomes my only option, then what?
He's already coming home tired, stretched thin by work.
And I don't even know what my mom thinks about all this,
whether she believes it would work,
or fall apart,
or just be one more thing
that wears me down.
She doesn't say it,
but I feel something unsaid between the lines.

The Barrier
And I can't drive.
That's the wall I hit every time.
My mom reminds me of it constantly,
as if distance isn't just miles
but proof I shouldn't trust myself.

The Search
I need to job hunt,
even with everything already heavy.
My portfolio sits unfinished.
My mom asks why I'm behind,
but she doesn't see the part of me
hoping, quietly,
that maybe I won't have to leave him.

The Uncertainty
What job fits me
and won't be swallowed by AI?
Writing, UX, editing, accessibility,
the roles I feel pulled toward.
But my mom only trusts
the kind of job that "makes real money."
To her, accounting is the only acceptable path,
and English or writing
is a hobby dressed up as work.
She wants security.
I want something that feels like mine.

The Body
And then there's my body,
slow, watched, misread.
My mom says I need to wear makeup,
fix my hair,
look "acceptable."

Her advice feels like armor
and also like warning.
But with him,
I never feel like too much
or not enough.
Just me.

The Voice
She says I'm not ready to live alone,
that I'll be a burden to him,
that his parents will see me
as someone he has to manage.
And yes, he's felt my heaviness before,
but only because of the insecurities I carry,
not because he's ever seen me as a burden.
With him, I feel chosen.
Safe.
Home.

The What-If
Could I stay where I am now?
My mom says she'd help me
and she fully supports me using Uber,
but that doesn't erase the questions,
the cost,
the isolation,
the way getting anywhere always feels like a puzzle.
Even with her support,
I don't know how everything fits together.

The Spiral
So I spiral.
Trying to juggle my first real relationship,
my job,
my classes.
My mom's caution wraps around me
like a seatbelt I didn't fasten,
but he's the one
who makes breathing easier.

The Loop
Still, I think about it again
and again,
until the thought circles back,
softly humming:

what happens next,
to us,
to me,
and how do I choose a future
that doesn’t pull me
away from him?